

Before I retired I was asked to speak at a high-school Career Day. I told a couple of jokes, talked about public accounting, and asked for questions. One of them was, "What do you physically *do* at work?"

I thought it over and answered as best I could: "I talk on the phone all day, just like everyone else I know."

I think the kids got the point. Maybe "talk on the phone *all day*" isn't precise. You also go to meetings. You make budgets, remake them, cut them by 10 percent, then forget about them until review time. You read memos, write memos, lose memos, and ignore memos. You approve expense accounts. You complete your personal evaluation form each year. But when you get off your high horse, and remember the bathtub test, "I talk on the phone" pretty much describes your business day. Almost anything you do in retirement seems more important than that.

Remember that work was just talking on the phone.

ALTERNATIVE VIEWS OF LIFE

You're a candidate for retirement when you have enough money to retire. The ideal amount is \$400,000 or \$500,000, and you may be 35 or 45 when you get there. At that point you can "stop working and start living."

But what is "living"?

Before I give you an answer that works for me, let me tell you a little about two answers that didn't.

A decade or so ago I hadn't even thought about "what is living?" I came out of the Stanford M.B.A. program a custom-made bowling ball and hurled myself down the alley of life. I rolled through the first career years on a clearly defined trajectory, gaining momentum along the way. I call this the "keep your head down" approach to life. The only rough period I recall was when I turned 29 and had a Thirties Crisis.